

Closed-Loop Bayesian Optimization of Multi-Material 3D-Printed Tensegrity-Inspired Energy Absorbers

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Abstract

Tensegrity-inspired architectures—rigid struts suspended within a continuous flexible network—exhibit tunable nonlinear responses and high strength-to-weight ratios, motivating their use in lightweight energy-absorbing and protective structures. Multi-material fused deposition modeling (FDM) can co-print rigid (PLA) struts and flexible (TPU) elements in a single build, but the resulting design space—strut geometry, tension-element cross-section, connectivity topology, and unit-cell tiling—is too large to explore by trial and error. We present a closed-loop experimental campaign that uses Bayesian optimization (BO) to drive a design–print–test workflow operating directly on physical measurements, without relying on finite-element simulation.

1 Introduction and Motivation

Tensegrity structures combine compression-only members with a pre-tensioned tension network to achieve stiffness without rigid joinery [1]. Their nonlinear, often load-limiting force–displacement response makes them attractive for impact mitigation, packaging, and wearable protective gear. Idealized cable–strut tensegrities are difficult to manufacture at scale, but *tensegrity-inspired* architectures fabricated by multi-material FDM retain much of the desirable mechanical behavior while remaining manufacturable [2,3]. PLA provides rigid struts; TPU provides flexible, rate-dependent tension elements whose intrinsic damping is an asset for energy absorption.

The challenge is that small geometric and topological changes can produce large changes in measured response, and high-fidelity simulation of multi-material FDM specimens—including interfacial slip, print defects, and TPU rate-dependence—is expensive and often unreliable. Pure trial-and-error sweeps over the joint design space are also infeasible: even modest parameter resolutions yield thousands of candidates, each requiring print and test time. We instead treat the physical experiment as the source of truth and use BO to select which specimens are most informative to fabricate next.

2 Approach

2.1 Closed-Loop Workflow

Figure 1 summarizes the campaign. Each iteration proceeds in four steps: (i) a parameterized unit-cell design is instantiated from a candidate vector $\mathbf{x}$; (ii) the specimen is sliced and printed on a multi-material FDM system;

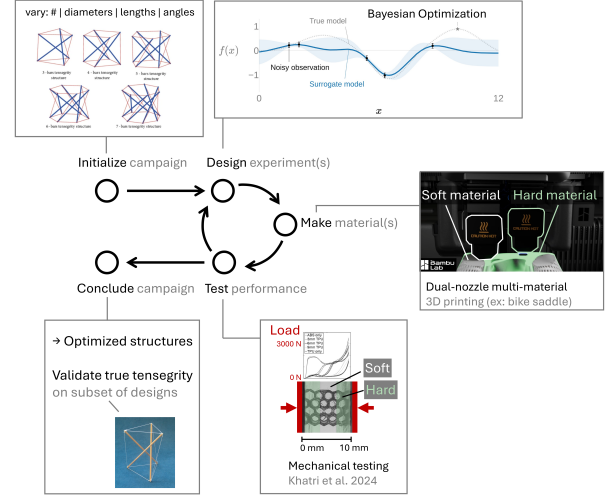


Figure 1: Closed-loop BO-driven workflow. Candidate tensegrity-inspired designs are printed and tested; measured metrics update a GP surrogate that proposes the next batch of designs.

(iii) it is tested under quasi-static compression and instrumented drop-weight impact; and (iv) the resulting performance metrics update a Gaussian-process (GP) surrogate, which a batch acquisition function queries to recommend the next set of candidates. Surrogate updating and experiment selection are automated; specimen handling, slicing, and test setup remain manual.

2.2 Design Space

We parameterize a family of unit cells using a core-wrapping architecture in which rigid PLA struts are enclosed by continuous TPU skins to improve interfacial interlocking and reduce delamination at the rigid–flexible interface. The design vector $\mathbf{x}$ includes strut diameter and length, tension-element width and thickness, strut count per unit cell, connectivity topology, and unit-cell tiling pattern. Bounds are chosen to remain within the printer’s resolution and overhang limits and to keep specimens in a common form factor for the fixtures.

2.3 Surrogate and Acquisition

The GP surrogate is trained on three measured performance metrics: peak transmitted force F_{peak} , specific energy absorption (SEA), and compaction efficiency η . We use independent GPs per objective with Matérn

kernels and learn length scales from the accumulated data. A batch acquisition function (e.g., q -noisy expected hypervolume improvement) selects the next set of candidates to balance multi-objective improvement against exploration of under-sampled regions of the design space [4]. Print-failure outcomes are recorded as constraints rather than discarded.

3 Methods

3.1 Fabrication

Specimens are fabricated on a multi-material FDM system capable of co-printing PLA and TPU within a single build. Print parameters (temperature, line width, infill, retraction) are held fixed within a batch to isolate the effect of the design variables. Each specimen is weighed and dimensionally inspected prior to testing so that mass and geometric deviations are available as covariates.

3.2 Mechanical Testing

Quasi-static compression is performed on a screw-driven load frame at a fixed nominal strain rate, with force–displacement recorded to densification. Drop-weight impact testing uses an instrumented tup at a fixed impact energy; transmitted force is captured at high sample rate, and specimens are imaged before and after impact to document failure modes. From each test we extract F_{peak} , SEA per unit mass, and compaction efficiency η , defined consistently across the campaign so that successive batches are directly comparable.

4 Expected Outcomes and Discussion

We will report how BO-selected designs evolve across iterations, how GP surrogate predictions and uncertainties change as data accumulate, and which Pareto-efficient trade-offs emerge between SEA and peak transmitted force within the explored design space. We will also discuss practical lessons for operating the closed-loop workflow, including handling of print failures, batch-to-batch variability in TPU response, the influence of the rigid–flexible interface on energy absorption, and the exploration–exploitation balance of the acquisition function under realistic experimental noise. We expect the campaign to highlight where physical experimentation is genuinely required versus where simpler analytical or surrogate shortcuts could be substituted in future work.

5 Conclusion

This work demonstrates a largely automated, experiment-driven closed-loop pipeline for designing multi-material 3D-printed tensegrity-inspired energy absorbers. By updating a GP surrogate directly from physical measurements, the workflow sidesteps the calibration burden of high-fidelity simulation while still providing principled, multi-objective design recommendations. The presented methodology is applicable to other

multi-material additively manufactured architectures whose performance is dominated by hard-to-simulate effects.

References

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